'Hello, my name is Barry Cooper,' he said, in a New Zealand accent.

'Hello,' I replied, working hard to look relaxed.

'It's a tricky wicket out here,' Barry continued, barely pausing for breath. 'Take it easy. Don't try anything flashy. Let's push the ball around; if we can get somewhere near 200, it'll be enough.'

'OK,' I said.

'And watch out for the off-spinner,' he added. 'That's Ijaz Ahmed, but it's not the famous one. This one played a couple of Tests and ODIs for Pakistan a few years ago. We'll take 20 or so from his 10 overs.'

The instructions passed in my left ear, and straight out of my right ear. Ijaz bowled. I aimed to drive him back over his head but miscued. The ball looped up in the air and fell just wide of mid-off. I survived, but Barry was not happy and, at the end of the over, he walked down the wicket and told me: 'I think I said you'll struggle to drive on this pitch.'

Again, I couldn't resist the challenge. In Ijaz's next over, I walked down the wicket and managed to drive a straight six, and then repeated the act off the next delivery and eventually scored 82 runs from 85 balls. I was enjoying myself – and continued to enjoy myself throughout the three months spent living among the wonderful people of Northern Ireland.

Barry was my friend, teammate and landlord, providing me with a room in his house, and I survived what was for me the new experience of cooking my own food and washing my own clothes. It was good to be taken out of my comfort zone and dropped into a whole new world. I tried to make myself useful during the week, but lived from weekend to weekend, from match to match, and was relieved that I could score runs under the burden of being the 'overseas player' at the club, against North Down, Donemana, Lisburn and Logan, and against Waringstown, Bangor and Downpatrick.

Against Cliftonville in mid-July, I scored 233 not out and became the first Carrick player to score a double century and, a week later, opening the batting against Instonians, I scored an unbeaten 208 in our total of